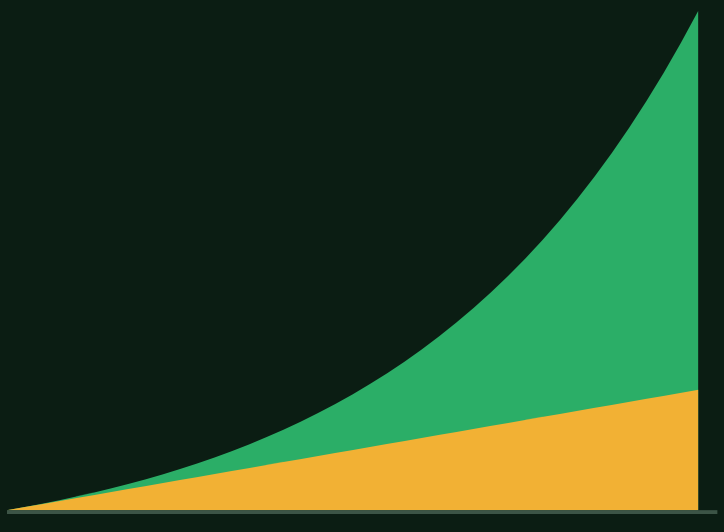
MONEY MADE SIMPLE · STARTER KIT

Open your first investing account in a weekend

The account types explained in plain English, how to compare providers without the sales pitch, index fund basics, and a checklist that gets you from zero to invested by Sunday night.

401(k) · IRA · Brokerage | Roth vs Traditional | Provider worksheet | Weekend checklist



Edition 1.0 · for US readers

Educational content. Not financial, tax or investment advice.

START HERE

What you'll have by Sunday night

An investing account that's open, funded, actually invested (not sitting in cash), and set to add money automatically every payday. Plus enough understanding to know why you chose what you chose.

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PLEASE READ: EDUCATION, NOT ADVICE

This guide explains how common US investment accounts and index funds work so you can make your own decisions. It is not financial, tax, legal or investment advice, it doesn't know your situation, and it doesn't recommend any company, fund or product. Tax rules and limits change every year: anything marked **verify** should be checked at irs.gov before you rely on it. All investing involves risk, including losing money. The examples use made-up people and assumed returns for illustration only; they are not predictions. If your situation is complicated (self-employment, high income, inheritance, stock options), a fee-only financial planner or tax professional is worth the cost.

No company in this guide paid to be included, and none is named. That's deliberate: the right provider for you depends on things only you can check, and page 9 shows you how.

CHAPTER 1

The weekend plan

About four hours in total, split into four sessions. Reading first, decisions second, clicking buttons last.

Sat AM

Understand (60 min)

- Read chapters 2 to 6 p.4–8
- Check your workplace plan: is there one, and a match?
- Decide which account comes first

Sat PM

Compare (60 min)

- Read chapter 7 p.9
- Fill in the worksheet for 2 or 3 providers p.10
- Pick one. Good enough beats perfect.

Sun AM

Choose what to buy (45 min)

- Read chapters 9 to 11 p.11–13
- Shortlist one or two broad, low-cost index funds offered by your provider
- Choose your monthly amount

Sun PM

Open, fund, automate (60 min)

- Open the account p.14
- Link your bank, transfer money, **buy** the fund
- Set up the automatic monthly investment
- Tick off the checklist p.15

What to have ready

- [ ] Your Social Security number (or ITIN)
- [ ] A government photo ID (driver's license or passport)
- [ ] Your bank's routing and account numbers
- [ ] Your employer's name and address
- [ ] Name, date of birth and contact details for a beneficiary
- [ ] Your workplace benefits login, if you have a plan at work

If you get stuck: it's completely fine to spread this over two weekends. The only real mistake is never starting, or opening the account and leaving the money in cash for a year (page 14 shows how to avoid that).

CHAPTER 2

Before you invest: a sensible order

Investing is for money you won't need for at least five years. Before that, it helps to have the ground under you solid. Many people work through something like this:

1. **A starter cash buffer**
   Some emergency savings in an insured bank or credit union account, so a surprise bill doesn't force you to sell investments at a bad moment or go into card debt. A common starting target is one month of essential bills, growing toward three to six months over time.

2. **Capture any employer match**
   If your workplace plan matches contributions, that match is part of your pay. Contributing enough to get all of it is one of the few no-brainers in personal finance, even while you work on other goals. Page 6 shows how matches work.

3. **High-interest debt**
   Paying off a credit card charging around 20% to 30% is a guaranteed saving of that rate. No investment reliably beats that, so many people clear high-rate debt before investing beyond the match. Low-rate debt (say under 5%) is more of a judgment call.

4. **Then: invest regularly**
   An IRA, more in your workplace plan, or a taxable account, depending on the next few chapters. The habit (a fixed amount, every payday, automatically) matters more than the starting amount.

Quick self-check

Question	Yes / No
Do I have some emergency cash that isn't invested?	
Am I getting my full employer match (or is there none)?	
Are my credit cards paid in full each month (or on a payoff plan)?	
Is this money I won't need for at least five years?	

Four yeses: you're in a good spot to start this weekend. A no doesn't mean you can't invest; it just tells you what else deserves attention. This order is a common rule of thumb, not a rule. Your situation may call for a different one.

CHAPTER 3

The account types at a glance

An account is the container; the investments (like index funds) go inside it. The container decides how the money is taxed and when you can take it out.

	401(k) / 403(b)	Traditional IRA	Roth IRA	Taxable brokerage
Who opens it	Your employer offers it; you enroll	You, at a provider you choose	You, at a provider you choose	You, at a provider you choose
Who can contribute	Eligible employees, via payroll	Anyone with earned income (or a spouse who has it)	Earned income, below an income limit verify	Anyone. No income test, no cap
Tax when money goes in	Traditional: pre-tax, lowers taxable pay now. Many plans also offer a Roth option (after-tax).	May be tax-deductible, depending on income and workplace plan coverage verify	No deduction: after-tax money	No deduction: after-tax money
Tax while it grows	None	None	None	Dividends and realized gains taxed each year
Tax when you take it out	Traditional: taxed as income. Roth: qualified withdrawals tax-free	Taxed as ordinary income	Qualified withdrawals tax-free; your contributions can come out any time	Only on gains; long-term gains usually taxed at lower rates
Early withdrawal	Before 59½, generally income tax + 10% additional tax, with exceptions	Same general rule, with exceptions	Contributions: anytime. Earnings: rules apply	Anytime (tax on any gain)
Employer match	**Often, yes**	No	No	No
Investment menu	Limited to the plan's list	Wide: whatever the provider offers	Wide: whatever the provider offers	Wide: whatever the provider offers

The one-line version. Workplace plan: match + payroll automation. IRA: tax benefits + your choice of provider and funds. Taxable: flexibility, no limits, no tax perks. Many people end up with more than one; you don't need them all this weekend.

Simplified for clarity. Rules on deductions, income limits, early-withdrawal exceptions and required withdrawals have details this table can't show. Check irs.gov (search "IRA FAQs" and "401(k) plans") for the current rules.

CHAPTER 4

Workplace plans: 401(k) and 403(b)

A 401(k) (companies) or 403(b) (schools, hospitals, non-profits) lets you invest straight from your paycheck. If you have one, it's usually the first place to look.

How the match works

Many employers add money when you contribute, up to a limit. Two common formulas, for someone earning $50,000 a year (illustrative):

Match formula	You put in (per year)	Employer adds	Total invested
100% match up to 4% of pay	$2,000	**$2,000**	$4,000
50% match up to 6% of pay	$3,000	**$1,500**	$4,500

Contribute less than the match limit and that extra pay simply isn't paid. Your plan's exact formula is in the plan documents or benefits portal; look for "employer match" or "matching contribution".

Vesting

Your own contributions are always yours. The employer's match may "vest" over a few years: leave before then and you could forfeit some of it. The plan's summary plan description tells you the schedule.

Traditional or Roth 401(k)?

If your plan offers both, the same question as for IRAs applies: pay tax now (Roth) or later (Traditional). See page 7. Employer match money has traditionally gone in pre-tax; check how your plan handles it.

What to pick inside the plan

Plans offer a menu. Look for low-cost broad index funds or a target-date fund near the year you expect to retire. Check each fund's **expense ratio** (page 12). If you do nothing, money may go into a default fund; check what it is.

Changing jobs

Your vested balance stays yours. You can usually leave it, move it to a new employer's plan, or roll it into an IRA. Avoid cashing out: taxes and penalties can take a big bite.

THIS WEEKEND

Log in to your benefits portal. Note: is there a plan, is there a match, what's the formula, what are you contributing now? If you're below the match, raising your contribution percentage takes five minutes and may be the most valuable thing you do all weekend.

CHAPTER 5

IRAs: Roth or Traditional?

An IRA (individual retirement account) is one you open yourself, at the provider of your choice. Both types grow without yearly tax. The difference is *when* you pay tax.

TRADITIONAL IRA

Contributions may be deductible now (lowering this year's tax). Withdrawals in retirement are taxed as income. **Tax later.**

ROTH IRA

No deduction now. Qualified withdrawals in retirement are tax-free, including all the growth. **Tax now.**

The one question: is your tax rate higher now, or later?

Take $1,000 of pre-tax income and assume it grows 5.7× over 30 years (a hypothetical 6% a year). Today's tax rate is 22%. What you'd have after tax:

Your tax rate in retirement	Traditional: invest $1,000, pay tax at the end	Roth: pay 22% now, invest $780	Better here
12% (lower than now)	$5,054	$4,480	Traditional
22% (same as now)	$4,480	$4,480	Tie
24% (higher than now)	$4,365	$4,480	Roth

When the rates are equal, the result is identical. So the choice is really a guess about your future tax rate. Early in a career, when income (and tax rate) is often lower than it will be later, many people lean Roth. In high-earning years, the Traditional deduction is worth more. Plenty of people split the difference and use both over time.

Other Roth features

- Your **contributions** (not earnings) can be withdrawn any time without tax or penalty.
- Earnings are tax-free once you're 59½ and the account has been open five years (with some exceptions).
- No required withdrawals during the original owner's lifetime.

Rules to check verify

- Roth IRA has an income limit; above it you can't contribute directly.
- Traditional IRA deductions phase out at certain incomes if you (or a spouse) have a workplace plan.
- You need earned income at least equal to what you contribute (spousal IRAs are the exception).

Illustration only: one lump sum, a fixed made-up return and flat tax rates. Real outcomes depend on your income, deductions, state taxes and future tax law. Not tax advice.

CHAPTER 6

Taxable brokerage accounts

A regular (taxable, "individual") brokerage account has no tax perks and no rules about who, how much, or when. That flexibility is the point.

When it can make sense

- You've used the tax-advantaged room you want to use this year.
- The goal is 5+ years away but isn't retirement (a home deposit in 7 years, say).
- You want money you can reach at any age without retirement-account rules.

How it's taxed (simplified)

- **Dividends** are taxed in the year you receive them, even if reinvested.
- When you sell for a profit, the gain is taxed. Held over one year: **long-term**, usually lower rates. One year or less: **short-term**, taxed like income.
- Your provider sends a tax form (1099) each year.

Broad index funds tend to be relatively tax-efficient because they trade less, which is one reason they're popular in taxable accounts.

2026 contribution limits verify at irs.gov

The IRS updates these every year, usually in the fall. These are the 2026 figures as announced; check irs.gov (search "401(k) and IRA contribution limits 2026") before you rely on them.

Account	2026 limit	Notes
401(k), 403(b), most 457 plans, TSP: your contributions	**$24,500**	Employer match doesn't count toward this; a higher combined limit applies
Catch-up, age 50+ (workplace plans)	+$8,000	Higher catch-up for ages 60–63 ($11,250); some high earners must make catch-ups as Roth
IRA (Traditional + Roth combined)	**$7,500**	Total across all your IRAs, not per account; can't exceed your earned income
IRA catch-up, age 50+	+$1,100	
Roth IRA income phase-out	$153k–$168k $242k–$252k	Modified AGI: single / head of household (first line), married filing jointly (second line)

IRA contributions for a tax year can usually be made until that year's tax-filing deadline (typically mid-April of the following year). Figures are for the 2026 tax year and may have been revised since this edition. Always confirm at irs.gov.

CHAPTER 7

How to compare providers

Any large, regulated brokerage can hold an IRA or a taxable account. You're not looking for "the best"; you're checking that nothing about the one you pick will quietly cost you. Ask each provider the same questions.

What to check	Why it matters	What good looks like
Account fees	Annual, maintenance, inactivity or "low balance" fees eat small accounts alive.	None, at any balance
Trading costs	Commissions on buying ETFs or mutual funds add up with monthly investing.	No commission on the funds you'll buy
Fund costs	The expense ratio is charged every year, forever. It matters more than any one-off fee (page 12).	Broad index funds with very low expense ratios available
Minimums	Minimums to open the account, or to buy a particular fund, can block a small start.	$0 to open; fund minimums you can meet
Fund choice	You need at least one broad, diversified, low-cost option.	Total-market, S&P 500, international, bond and target-date index funds or ETFs
Automatic investing	Automation is what makes the habit stick.	Recurring transfers *and* automatic purchases of your fund
Fractional shares	Lets every dollar get invested, even when a share costs more than you're adding.	Available for the funds you want
Protection	SIPC covers customers if a member brokerage firm fails (not investment losses).	SIPC member; check at sipc.org
Leaving fees	Some firms charge to transfer an account out.	Low or none; know the number
Security & service	You'll log in for decades.	Two-factor login; reachable humans; an app you'll actually use
Background	Disciplinary history is public.	Clean record on FINRA BrokerCheck

Red flags: pressure to decide today; "guaranteed" returns; anyone recommending products they earn a commission on without telling you; a push toward complex products (options, leverage, crypto, high-fee annuities) for your first account; sign-up bonuses that require trading frequently.

Robo-advisors (automated portfolio services) and target-date funds both offer hands-off investing. Robo-advisors often add an advisory fee on top of fund costs; compare the all-in yearly cost.

PRINTABLE

Provider comparison worksheet

Fill in one column per provider from their pricing and FAQ pages. If you can't find an answer in ten minutes, that's an answer too.

	Provider A	Provider B	Provider C
Name			
Account fee (yearly / inactivity)			
Minimum to open			
Commission on ETFs / mutual funds			
Lowest expense ratio: total-market or S&P 500 index fund			
Target-date index funds? Expense ratio?			
Fund minimum to buy			
Fractional shares?			
Automatic recurring investing?			
Fee to transfer out			
SIPC member? (sipc.org)			
BrokerCheck: anything notable?			
Two-factor login?			
App / site: easy to use?			
Account types offered (Roth, Traditional, taxable)			
Gut feeling (1-5)			

Decision rule: cross out any provider with account fees or commissions on the funds you'd buy. From the rest, pick the one with the lowest-cost broad index fund and automatic investing. If two tie, pick the app you like more. You'll use it for years.

CHAPTER 9

Index fund basics

An index fund buys every investment in a list (an "index") in proportion, instead of paying someone to pick winners. One purchase gets you a slice of hundreds or thousands of companies.

Why beginners like them

- **Diversified:** one company's bad year barely registers.
- **Low cost:** no stock-picking team to pay, so expense ratios are often a fraction of actively managed funds.
- **Simple:** you don't need opinions about individual companies.
- **Transparent:** you know what you own.

What they don't do

- They don't avoid market drops. When the market falls, a stock index fund falls with it, sometimes a lot, sometimes for years.
- They don't guarantee any return.
- A single-country stock fund is still concentrated in one market.

Common types

Type	What it holds	Typical role
Total US stock market	Practically every publicly traded US company, large to small	Core holding
S&P 500	About 500 large US companies	Core holding (large companies only)
Total international	Companies outside the US, developed and emerging markets	Adds global diversification
Total bond market	Many government and corporate bonds	Steadier; smaller drops and lower expected growth
Target-date fund	A mix of the above that shifts from stocks toward bonds as the target year approaches	All-in-one, hands-off

ETF or mutual fund?

Both can track the same index. **ETFs** trade during the day like a stock, usually with no fund minimum. **Index mutual funds** trade once a day at the closing price, sometimes with a minimum first purchase, and are easy to automate in fixed dollar amounts. For a long-term investor, either works. Compare expense ratios.

How many funds do I need?

Fewer than you'd think. Some people hold one target-date fund. Others hold a US fund and an international fund, adding a bond fund as they get closer to needing the money. More funds isn't more diversified if they all hold the same companies.

Fund categories are described generally. Before buying any fund, read its summary prospectus or fact sheet: what it holds, its expense ratio and its risks.

CHAPTER 10

Why fees matter, with numbers

The **expense ratio** is the yearly cost of a fund, as a percentage of what you have in it. It's taken out quietly, so you never see a bill. That's exactly why it's worth checking.

```
yearly cost ≈ amount invested × expense ratio
e.g. $10,000 × 0.50% = $50 a year  ·  $10,000 × 0.05% = $5 a year
```

$45 a year sounds like nothing. But the fee is charged on your whole balance, every year, and the money it takes can't compound for you. Here's $300 a month for 30 years, assuming a hypothetical 6% a year before fees:

Expense ratio	Yearly cost per $10,000	Balance after 30 years	Less than the 0.05% fund
0.05%	**$5**	**$298,489**	**–**
0.50%	$50	**$274,084**	$24,405
1.00%	$100	**$249,678**	$48,811

Same contributions ($108,000 in total), same market. The only difference is the fee: about $48,811 less with a 1% fee than with a 0.05% one.

Where to find it

On the fund's page at your provider, its fact sheet, or its prospectus. Look for "expense ratio" or "net expense ratio".

Other costs to look out for

Sales charges ("loads"), account fees, advisory fees (common with managed accounts and some robo-advisors) and trading commissions. Add them up to compare the all-in yearly cost.

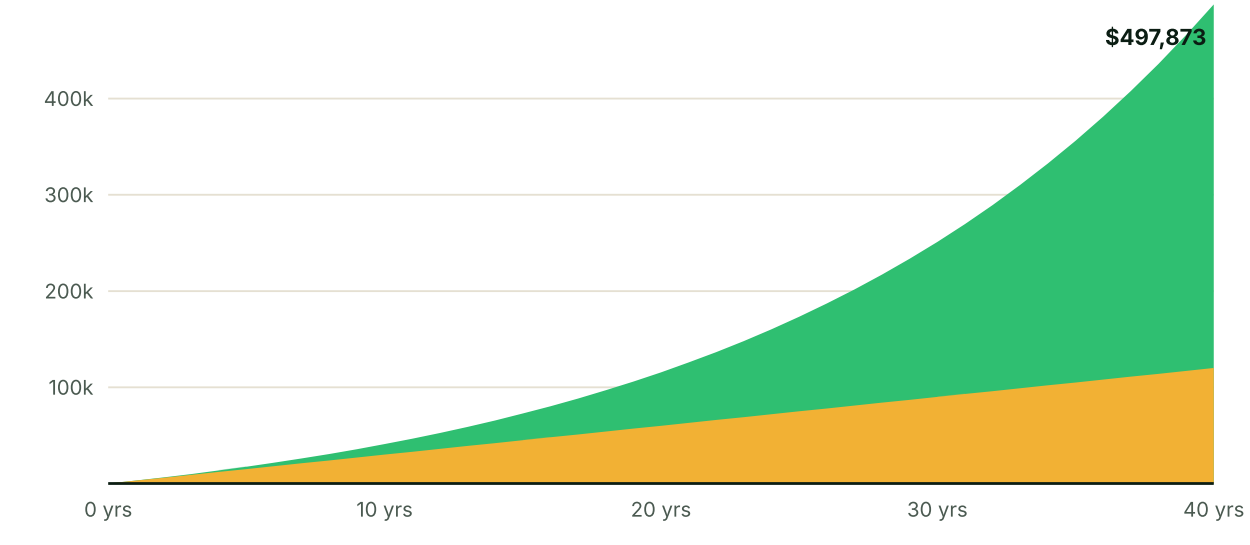
Calculation: monthly contributions at the end of each month, monthly compounding, fee approximated by subtracting it from the assumed annual return. The 6% return is a made-up round number for illustration, not a prediction. Real returns vary year to year and can be negative.

CHAPTER 11

Compounding, worked examples

Compounding means your returns start earning returns. It's slow at first and then surprisingly fast, which is why time in the market matters more than the starting amount.

$250 a month for 40 years at a hypothetical 6% a year



Monthly amounts over time (hypothetical 6% a year)

Per month	10 years	20 years	30 years	40 years
$100	$16,388 put in $12,000	$46,204 put in $24,000	$100,452 put in $36,000	$199,149 put in $48,000
$250	$40,970 put in $30,000	$115,510 put in $60,000	$251,129 put in $90,000	$497,873 put in $120,000
$500	$81,940 put in $60,000	$231,020 put in $120,000	$502,258 put in $180,000	$995,745 put in $240,000

The return assumption changes a lot

$200/mo, 30 yrs	Ends at
4% a year	$138,810
6% a year	$200,903
8% a year	$298,072
Total put in	$72,000

Starting early (made-up people)

Alex invests $200/month from 25 to 35, then stops: $24,000 in. Sam invests $200/month from 35 to 65: $72,000 in. At 65, at 6%: Alex has about **$197,395**, Sam about **$200,903**. Alex put in a third as much and ends up close.

All figures computed with monthly contributions at the end of each month and monthly compounding, before taxes, fees and inflation. Returns are assumptions, not predictions; real returns vary every year and can be negative for long stretches. Try your own numbers at investor.gov (compound interest calculator).

CHAPTER 12

Opening the account, step by step

The exact screens vary by provider, but every one follows roughly this path. Allow about 30 minutes, plus a few business days for money to arrive.

1. **Choose the account type**
   "Roth IRA", "Traditional IRA" or "Individual brokerage". Opening an account doesn't commit you to investing any amount yet.

2. **Enter your details**
   Name, address, date of birth, SSN, employment and some financial questions. These are legally required (to verify identity and assess suitability). Answer honestly.

3. **Name a beneficiary**
   Who inherits the account. It's quick and easy to skip, and skipping it can create a mess for your family. Add a primary and, if you can, a contingent beneficiary.

4. **Turn on security**
   Two-factor authentication and a unique password. Never share login codes with anyone who contacts you.

5. **Link your bank and transfer money**
   With routing and account numbers or a bank login. For an IRA, choose which **tax year** the contribution is for if asked.

6. **Buy your investment. Don't skip this.**
   Money you transfer usually lands in a cash "settlement" or "core" position. **It isn't invested until you buy something.** Search for your chosen fund, enter a dollar amount and confirm. A surprising number of people find their IRA sat in cash for years.

7. **Automate it**
   Set a recurring transfer from your bank on payday *and* an automatic investment into your fund. Check both are switched on; some providers treat them separately.

8. **Then leave it alone**
   Check in a few times a year, raise the amount when your pay goes up, and resist selling when the market drops. Drops are normal and expected.

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The weekend checklist

Tick as you go. Nothing on here needs to be perfect, only done.

Saturday

- [ ] Read chapters 2 to 6
- [ ] Emergency cash exists (or a plan to build it)
- [ ] Checked workplace plan and its match
- [ ] Contributing enough to get the full match
- [ ] Decided first account: Roth IRA / Traditional IRA / 401(k) / taxable
- [ ] Checked this year's limits at irs.gov
- [ ] Compared 2–3 providers on the worksheet
- [ ] Picked a provider: _____

Sunday

- [ ] Read chapters 9 to 11
- [ ] Chose a fund: _____
- [ ] Its expense ratio: _____ %
- [ ] Read its fact sheet or summary prospectus
- [ ] Monthly amount: $ _____

Open, fund, automate

- [ ] Account opened
- [ ] Beneficiary added
- [ ] Two-factor login on
- [ ] Bank linked
- [ ] First transfer sent: $ _____
- [ ] Fund **bought** once the money arrived (not left in cash)
- [ ] Recurring transfer set for payday
- [ ] Automatic investment into the fund set
- [ ] Login details stored safely

Diary dates

- [ ] In 1 week: confirm the fund was actually bought
- [ ] In 1 month: confirm the automatic investment ran
- [ ] Every January: check new limits, raise the amount
- [ ] At every raise: raise contributions too

DONE?

Then you're an investor. The hard part (starting) is behind you. The next part is mostly patience.

CHAPTER 14

Glossary

401(k) / 403(b)	Employer-sponsored retirement plans funded from your paycheck. 403(b)s are for schools, hospitals and non-profits.
Asset allocation	How your money is split between stocks, bonds and cash. The biggest driver of both growth and how bumpy the ride is.
Beneficiary	The person (or people) who inherit an account. Named on the account, separate from a will.
Bond	A loan to a government or company that pays interest. Usually steadier than stocks, with lower expected returns.
Brokerage account	An account for buying and holding investments. "Taxable" or "individual" means no special tax treatment.
Capital gain	Profit when you sell for more than you paid. Long-term (held over a year) is usually taxed at lower rates than short-term.
Compounding	Earning returns on previous returns, so growth builds on itself over time.
Diversification	Spreading money across many investments so no single one can sink you.
Dividend	A share of company profits paid to shareholders. Funds pass them on; you can reinvest them automatically.
Dollar-cost averaging	Investing a fixed amount on a schedule, regardless of price. It's what automatic monthly investing does.
Earned income	Pay from work (wages, self-employment). Needed to contribute to an IRA.
ETF	Exchange-traded fund: a fund that trades during the day like a stock.
Expense ratio	A fund's yearly cost, as a percentage of your balance in it.
Fiduciary	Someone legally required to act in your best interest. Ask any adviser whether they are one, at all times, in writing.
Fractional shares	Buying part of a share, so every dollar can be invested.
Index	A list of investments that represents a market (for example, the S&P 500).
Index fund	A fund that holds everything in an index, rather than picking investments.
IRA	Individual retirement account, opened by you. Traditional (tax later) or Roth (tax now).
Match	Money your employer adds to your workplace plan when you contribute.
Mutual fund	A pooled fund priced once a day. Can be index or actively managed.
Rebalancing	Selling a bit of what's grown and buying what's lagged to get back to your chosen mix.
RMD	Required minimum distribution: yearly withdrawals the IRS requires from most pre-tax retirement accounts from a certain age. Roth IRAs have none for the original owner.
Roth 401(k)	A Roth option inside a workplace plan: after-tax contributions, tax-free qualified withdrawals.
Rollover	Moving a retirement account to another provider or plan without triggering tax, when done correctly.
Settlement fund	The cash holding where deposits land before you buy. Not the same as being invested.
SIPC	Securities Investor Protection Corporation. Protects customers of a member firm that fails, within limits. Doesn't protect against market losses.
Target-date fund	An all-in-one fund that gets more conservative as its target year approaches.
Vesting	When employer contributions become fully yours. Your own contributions are always 100% vested.

CHAPTER 15

Where to verify, and the fine print

Rules and limits change. These official and non-commercial sources are where to check anything in this guide before you act on it.

Source	Use it for
irs.gov	Current contribution limits, Roth IRA income limits, IRA deduction rules, early-withdrawal exceptions, required distributions. Search "IRA FAQs", "Retirement topics" and "401(k) and IRA contribution limits".
investor.gov (SEC)	Plain-English guides to funds, fees and fraud, plus a free compound interest calculator.
brokercheck.finra.org	Look up a brokerage firm or financial professional's registration and disciplinary history.
sipc.org	Check whether a brokerage is a SIPC member and what SIPC protection does and doesn't cover.
dol.gov (EBSA)	Your rights in employer retirement plans, including fee disclosures and vesting.
Your plan documents	Your employer's match formula, vesting schedule, fund menu and fees: the summary plan description and annual fee disclosure.

How the examples were calculated

Every number in this guide's examples was computed, not estimated: monthly contributions added at the end of each month, monthly compounding at the stated annual rate divided by 12, no taxes, no inflation. Fee examples subtract the expense ratio from the assumed annual return. The people (Alex, Sam) and the $50,000 salary are made up. Assumed returns of 4%, 6% and 8% a year are round numbers chosen to show sensitivity; they aren't forecasts and they aren't based on any particular fund.

DISCLAIMER

This guide is general education about how investment accounts and index funds work in the United States. It is not financial, investment, tax or legal advice, and it is not a recommendation to buy or sell any security or to use any particular company. Investing involves risk, including the possible loss of principal. Past performance does not guarantee future results. Tax treatment depends on your circumstances and on laws that change. Contribution limits and income thresholds shown are for the 2026 tax year as published at the time of writing and must be verified at irs.gov. Consider talking to a qualified, fee-only professional about your specific situation. The author is not a registered investment adviser or tax professional.

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